

Uzbekistan



Sharing what is left of the Aral Sea with its neighbor, Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan lies on the ancient Silk Road between Asia and Europe. It is the most populous central Asian republic.



GEOGRAPHY

Arid and semiarid plains in much of the west. Fertile, irrigated farmland in the east lies below the peaks of the western Pamirs.



CLIMATE

Harsh continental climate. Summers can be extremely hot and dry; winters are cold.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Complex ethnic makeup. Ex-Communists are in firm control, but traditional social patterns based on clan, religion, and region have reemerged. Constitutional measures aim to control the influence of Islam: activities against Islamists have drawn international condemnation. Most people live in the fertile east. Birth rates are high, and the status of women continues to be low.



THE ECONOMY

Highly regulated. Reserves of natural gas, oil, coal, gold (has one of the world's largest gold mines), and other minerals. Cash crop is cotton: requires much irrigation. Grain imports necessary.



INSIGHT: *The Aral Sea has shrunk to just a tenth of its former size, due to diversion of rivers for irrigation*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Uzbekistan

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Tashkent

POPULATION: 27.5 million

TOTAL AREA: 172,741 sq. miles
(447,400 sq. km)

DENSITY: 159 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Uzbek*, Russian, Tajik, Kazakh

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 88%, Orthodox Christian 9%, other 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Uzbek 80%, other 6%, Russian 6%, Tajik 5%, Kazakh 3%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Som = 100 tiyin